

Order Passeriformes continued

Family Corvidae

Crows and jays

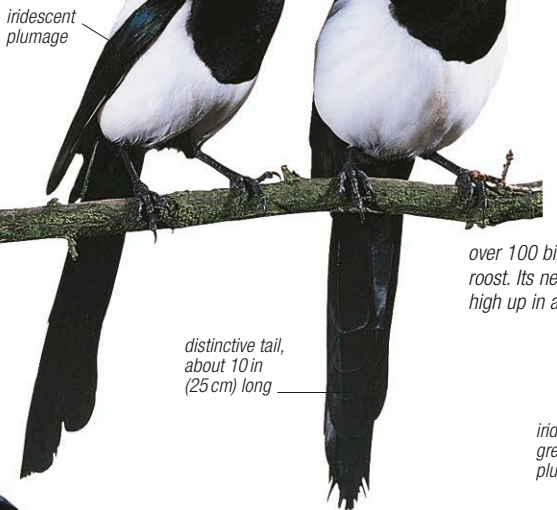
Length 8–26 in (20–66 cm)

Species 130

Habitat All terrestrial

Crows and their relatives are distributed across almost every part of the world, except the Arctic and Antarctic. They are the most highly developed of all birds—intelligent, sociable, and very adaptable, with most of them feeding on a wide range of foods. Many members of this family have mainly

black plumage, although some of the jays and magpies are highly colored. Found in open countryside and woodland, in both lowland and upland areas, crows are not migratory birds, although they may move locally between seasons. They usually nest as separate pairs but a notable exception in this regard is the rook, which nests in colonies. A typical crow nest holds 2–8 eggs and is built of twigs, in trees or bushes, or sometimes in holes.

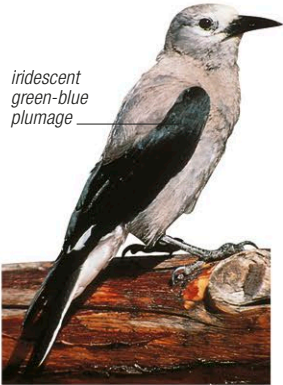


BLACK-BILLED MAGPIE
Similar in appearance to the common magpie, *Pica hudsonia* is found in central and western North America. This is a common bird, 18½ in (47 cm) in length, which lives well alongside humans. Gregarious outside of the breeding season, over 100 birds may gather at a winter roost. Its nest is a domed pile of sticks, high up in a tree.



EURASIAN JAY
The many subspecies of *Garrulus glandarius* have slightly different head markings; all are 13 in (33 cm) long. Distributed across Europe and Asia, this bird is a fairly common inhabitant of woodland, but is also found in many other habitats, such as rain forests and taiga. Across much of its range, the Eurasian jay collects and stores acorns as winter food.

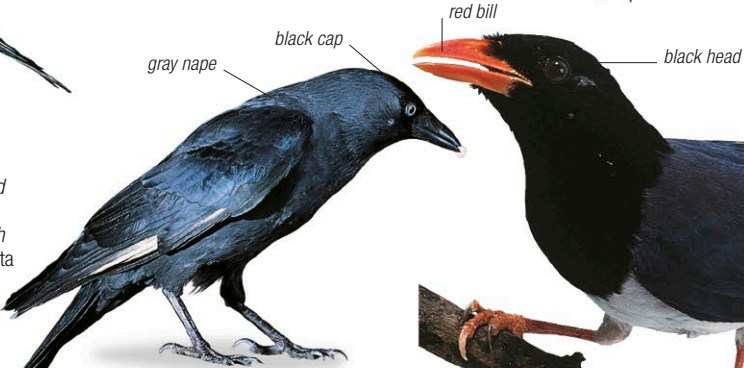
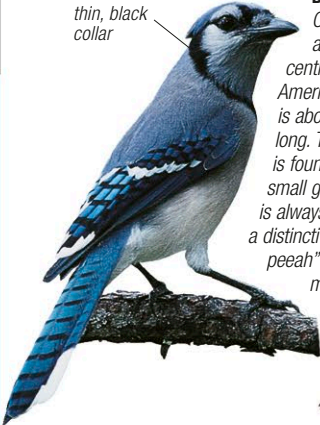
RED-BILLED CHOUGH
Pyrrhocorax pyrrhocorax is a gregarious bird, particularly outside the breeding season. It forages for insects, especially ants, and also eats berries. During courtship, it performs spectacular aerobatics. The nest is built either on a cliff ledge or in a cave. Measuring 6 in (14 cm) in length, this bird is found in mountain and rocky coastal areas in Europe, North Africa, and South Asia.



CLARK'S NUTCRACKER
Found only in the mountains of western North America, *Nucifraga columbiana* inhabits juniper and pine woodland. Agile when swooping through canyons, it does not fly long distances and is usually found on treetops. It is 12 in (30 cm) long.



BLUE JAY
Common in woodland and parkland across central and eastern North America, *Cyanocitta cristata* is about 12 in (30 cm) long. This bird is found in pairs or small groups, and is always noisy, with a distinctive "peeah peeah" call. It uses mud to build its nest.



WESTERN JACKDAW
Widespread across Europe, West Asia, and parts of North Africa, this is a familiar crow that often flies and feeds with rooks. A farmland bird in much of its range, *Coloeus monedula* also inhabits gorges and sea cliffs, nesting there as well as in buildings and holes in trees. It roosts in flocks of several thousands outside the breeding season. It is about 13½ in (34 cm) long.



RED-BILLED BLUE MAGPIE
This striking species, 27 in (68 cm) long, has a tail that itself measures 18½ in (47 cm). Found up to a height of 4,900 ft (1,500 m) in the deciduous forests of South and Southeast Asia, *Urocissa erythrorhynchos* hunts in flocks at lower levels. Its nest is a rough, flimsy cup in a tree.



NORTHERN RAVEN
At 26 in (65 cm), *Corvus corax* is the largest crow in the Northern Hemisphere, and is found in North and Central America, Europe, Asia, and North Africa. It lives in open habitats as well as in urban areas in some parts of its range, and up to 20,900 ft (6,350 m) on Mount Everest, often nesting when snow is still on the ground.



CARRION CROW
Regarded as the archetypal crow by many people in Europe, the all-black *Corvus corone* lives in many habitats, including woodland, moorland, farmland, and towns. About 20 in (50 cm) long, it is also found (but with gray in its plumage) through West Asia and in eastern Asia, including Vietnam and Korea. It is a solitary nester, usually making its home in a tree, although in mountainous areas, cliff ledges are often used.